NORTH CURRENT
Fact-check column, August 2026

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Slug: FACTCHECK HEAT ISLAND

Head: # Fact check: Are downtown nights 15 degrees hotter?

Dek: *The Twin Cities heat island is real, and on the worst nights the gap runs into the low teens. On an ordinary summer night, and next to the suburbs, it is far smaller.*

Rating: **Partly true**

Art: Map (Lena Fischer): summer average overnight lows, shown as the difference from the airport station, in whole degrees Fahrenheit.

By Owen Brandt
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About 430 words, plus sources

The claim: "Downtown nights are 15°F hotter," says a heat-wave explainer post making the rounds this month, comparing the city with the suburbs. It doesn't say which nights it means.

The science is real: Pavement, roofs and brick soak up heat during the day and give it back after dark, so a city cools off more slowly than the countryside once the sun goes down. Downtown has fewer trees and less open ground to cool the air, and its buildings, traffic and air conditioners add heat of their own. Researchers call it the urban heat island. It is strongest on clear, calm nights, when no wind mixes the warm city air with cooler air from outside it.

The numbers: The best local evidence comes from a University of Minnesota network of temperature sensors spread across the Twin Cities, from downtown out past the suburbs to farm fields at the edge of the metro. On the hottest, calmest nights, the network had downtown Minneapolis running in the low teens warmer than those farm fields. That is close to the post's number.

On a typical summer night, the gap was closer to 5 to 7 degrees. Against the inner-ring suburbs, which have streets, roofs and parking lots of their own, it was smaller still.

Compared with what: The post takes the extreme and treats it as the norm, and it changes the comparison. Fifteen degrees is a worst night against open country. It is not an average night against Edina.

The map with this column shows summer averages, not single nights, with each sensor shown as the difference from the official weather station at the airport.

Why it still matters: None of this makes the heat island small, and the worst nights are the dangerous ones. When a heat wave stalls over the metro and downtown never cools off, people without air conditioning get no relief from one day to the next. Those are the nights that put people in the hospital. The Minnesota Department of Health's heat reports make the same point: warm nights keep the body from recovering, and older adults, people with heart or lung disease and people who live alone face the most risk.

Rating: Partly true. Downtown nights are hotter, sometimes much hotter. On the worst of them, the gap against open country runs into the low teens. But 15 degrees hotter than the suburbs, as a rule, is an overstatement. On a typical summer night the difference is closer to 5 to 7 degrees, and less than that next to the inner-ring suburbs.

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SOURCES

1. University of Minnesota: Twin Cities urban heat island sensor network, overnight temperatures at downtown, suburban and rural sites.
2. National Weather Service, Twin Cities office: summer climate summaries for the Minneapolis-St. Paul airport station.
3. Minnesota Department of Health: extreme heat and health reports.